

Lawrence Knowles

Research and Development Leadership | Agentic AI | HR and Payroll

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Executive profile

Board-level technology and commercial leader with more than three decades in HR, payroll and enterprise software. Given a blank-sheet brief to create iTrent in 1997 and PeopleFirst in 2013, including predictive analytics and machine learning within PeopleFirst. Combines product architecture, technical team leadership and full P&L experience with current hands-on research into governed AI agents, LLM orchestration and retrieval-based applications.

Built and led a team of 60 technical specialists and grew MidlandHR turnover from £8m to £24m in four years. Experienced in translating research and technology into product direction, enterprise customer delivery and commercial partnerships, working directly with chairmen, CEOs and boards.

Core expertise

Agentic AI and LLM orchestration • Retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) • Predictive analytics and machine learning • HR and payroll platforms • Cloud architecture and SaaS • R&D strategy and product roadmaps • Technical team development • Enterprise delivery and assurance • Commercial partnerships • Budgets and P&L

Current research and applied AI

Creator and Independent R&D | Agent Control and Tsunora

- Created Agent Control, a governed runtime for AI work, with scoped jobs, provider-neutral execution, authority controls, verification, retained evidence and recovery. Recent work includes context-aware admission, retrieval, checkpointing and bounded repair for local-model tasks.
- Created Tsunora, an experimental digital-work operating environment derived from Agent Control. Its Digital Labour Exchange connects work to qualified workers through admission controls, allocation, outcome verification and accounting; workforce research covers approval pauses, containment and recovery.
- Established an evidence-led approach to evaluation: frozen workloads, retained failures, independent outcome checks and explicit qualification limits. Published Tsunora clean-install qualification records 2,482 passing tests, zero failures and one environment-dependent skip.
- Developed retrieval-based AI work for Ask Collingham, binding generated claims to retrieved source records, applying deterministic validation and presenting provenance. Implemented and verified this claim-bound pipeline in staging.

Tsunora remains experimental research software; production HR/payroll integrations and model-backed workforce execution are separately unqualified. Public work: github.com/lozknowles/agent-control and github.com/lozknowles/tsunora.

Current advisory experience

Founder and CEO | KNect Solutions Ltd | June 2016 to present

HRMS and data analytics advisory work spanning product roadmap direction, collaboration with a development team in Colombo, executive advice and CEO mentoring, major client contract renegotiation, and UK market development for a Boston-based analytics business.

Executive and technology career

Associate Director | Deloitte | October 2019 to June 2021

Customer and business development role focused on successful HR and payroll implementations: system selection, current-state audit and implementation oversight. Supported the Kemp Little acquisition team, working with global Deloitte and Kemp Little partners on conflict-of-interest checks.

Managing Director Corporate | SafeHR | June 2015 to June 2016

- Held full P&L responsibility for corporate products and services spanning HR, background screening, financials and credit control. Restructured the executive team and reporting in the first nine months to support growth.
- Led the move from legacy technology to a .NET platform with a robust software development lifecycle; migrated over 20% of the legacy customer base to the new platform.
- Reworked marketing and the market proposition, established a strategic partnership with Liberata, and secured a major city council customer to open the public sector market.

MidlandHR now MHR | September 1991 to June 2015

Progressed from software development and team management to software direction, managing director and board-level technology leadership across HR, talent management, payroll and outsourcing.

Enterprise Director | October 2014 to June 2015

Led strategic enterprise sales and product evangelism, targeting private-sector organisations with more than 8,000 employees and aligning product capability with customer requirements.

Vice Chairman Technology | September 2010 to October 2014

- Given a blank-sheet brief for PeopleFirst in 2013. Architected a new enterprise-scale, multi-tenant Microsoft Azure platform and created predictive analytics and machine learning within the HR system.
- Hired and inspired a team of 60 specialists across .NET development, testing and architecture. Worked directly with the Chairman, CEO and board, combining strategic research with daily development engagement.
- Owned product architecture roadmaps and worked with Microsoft and industry analysts on technology strategy. Platform work covered load and volume testing, security hardening, geographic resilience, scalability and SaaS readiness.

Managing Director | July 2001 to September 2010

- Held full P&L responsibility, reporting to the CEO and Chairman. Grew turnover from £8m to £24m in four years through investment in people and product, sales leadership and customer experience.
- Expanded the business from public-sector payroll into HR solutions across multiple sectors, aligning product development, marketing, executive-led procurement and customer references.

Software Director | September 1996 to June 2001

Given a blank-sheet brief by the Chairman to create iTrent in 1997, MidlandHR's next-generation HR system. Also attended the boards of two other group companies in a non-executive capacity.

Software development and team management | September 1991 to September 1996

Held software development and team management roles before appointment as Software Director.

Earlier work and professional development

Founder, Images Software: developed games in 6502, Z80 and 68000 assembler; 11 games published, with four appearing in the Gallup top ten in one month.

Cranfield General Management Programme, 1999. Institute of Directors training, 2001–2005, in strategy, finance, marketing and leadership. Further training in Azure and cloud architecture, Cloud Security Alliance CCSK, and HR technology workshops with Naomi Bloom and industry analysts.

Community work: Trustee and Executive for Digital, Collingham and District Local History Society, applying technology to archive digitisation. References and recommendations: lozknowles.com/references.html and linkedin.com/in/lozknowles.